

TITUS

THE

EPISTLE OF S. PAUL, THE APOSTLE,

TO TITUS.

PREFACE.

The design of this epistle is much the same as in the two former to Timothy. He had made this his beloved son Titus, chief bishop of Crete; in which island were formerly a hundred cities, on which account it was called Hecatompolis.

It is now called Candy. We have a commentary of S. Jerom on this epistle, tom.

iv, p. 409. E. B. Wi. — Titus was an uncircumcised Gentile: we know not on what occasion he attached himself to S. Paul. It is however certain that he was a great utility to S. Paul in the government of the Church. — S. Paul having preached the faith in the island of Crete, left his beloved Titus there to finish the work which he had begun.

Afterwards the apostle, on a journey to Nicopolis, a city of Macedonia, wrote this epistle to Titus; in which he directs him to ordain bishops and priests for the different cities, shewing him the principal qualities necessary for a bishop, also gives him particular advice for his own conduct to his flock, exhorting him to hold to strictness of discipline, but seasoned with lenity. It was written about thirty-three years after our Lord's ascension. Ch.

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TITUS 1

CHAPTER I.

Ver. 1. According to the faith of the elect of God; that is, of the Christians, now the elect people of God. — Truth, which is according to

piety: because there may be truth also in things that regard not piety. By truth, S. Chrys. here understands the truth of the Christian religion, as distinguished from the Jewish worship, which consisted in a great measure in the figures and types of truth. Wi.

Ver. 2. Who[1] lieth not, or who cannot lie, being truth itself. — Hath promised; that is, decreed to give life everlasting to his faithful servants. — Before the times of the world.[2] Lit. before secular times. Wi.

Ver. 3. Manifested his word. S. Jerom understands the word incarnate; others, the word of God preached, which S. Paul says, was committed to him, &c. See S. Chrys. p. 383. Wi.

Ver. 4. To Titus, my beloved, (in the Greek, my true and[3] genuine son, . . .

grace and peace. In the present ordinary Greek copies is added mercy, which the Prot. translators followed; but it is judiciously omitted by Dr. Wells, as not found in the best MSS. nor in S. Chrys. Greek edition, nor in the ancient Greek and Latin Fathers. Wi.

Ver. 5. That thou shouldst,[4] &c. The sense cannot be, that he was to change any thing S. Paul had ordered, but to settle things which S. Paul had not time to do; for example, to establish priests[5] in the cities, that is to say, bishops, as the same are called bishops v. 7; and, as S. Chrys. and others observe, it is evident from this very place, that the word presbyter was then used to signify either priests or bishops. If S. Jerom here meant that bishops were only placed over priests by ecclesiastical and not by divine institution, as some have expounded his words, his singular opinion against so many others is not to be followed. Wi. — That the ordaining of priests belongs only to bishops, is evident from the Acts and from S. Paul's epistles to Timothy and Titus. It is true, S. Jerom seems to express himself as if in the primitive Church there was no great difference between priests and bishops, yet he constantly excepts giving holy orders, (ep. 85) as also confirming the baptized, by giving them the Holy Ghost by imposition of hands and holy chrism; (dial. cont. Lucif. c. iv.) which pre-eminence he attributes to bishops

only. To assert that there is no distinction between a priest and bishop is an old heresy, condemned as such by the Church. See S. Epiphanius, hæc. 75. S. Austin, hæc 53.

Ver. 6. Without crime. See the like qualifications, 1 Tim. iii. Wi. — These words if taken in their strictest meaning, do not seem to have all the force S. Paul meant them to have. For it is not sufficient that a bishop be free from great crimes; he ought, moreover to lead such a life as to draw others by his example to the practice of virtue. Calmet. — If we consult all antiquity we shall find, that if in the early infancy of the Church some who had been once married were ordained to the ministry, we shall find that after their ordination they abstained from the use of marriage. See S. Epiph. l. iii. cont. hæc. and l. ii.

hæres. 59.

Ver. 7. Not proud.[6] The Greek word is of an extensive signification, which the Protestants have translated self-willed. The Latin interpreter (2 Pet. ii. 10.) for the same Greek word has put, pleasing themselves; as it were never pleased with others, the unhappy disposition of a proud man. Wi.

Ver. 8. Continent:[7] though both the Latin and Greek word signify in general, one that hath abstained, or contained, and overcome himself: yet it is particularly used for such as contain themselves from carnal pleasures. Wi.

Ver. 10. For there are also many. S. Paul here alludes principally to the Jews, who were of the circumcision, from whom S. Paul suffered much during the greater part of his life. They constantly enforced the necessity of the new converted Gentiles observing the law of Moses, and of their being circumcised, if they wished to be saved. There were many Jews of this description in Crete; to resist whom, S. Paul here tells Titus he ought to appoint bishops remarkable for their zeal and learning. Josephus. Socrates, l.

ii. c. 38. Hist. Eccles. — Especially they who are of the circumcision; which shews who were chiefly the false teachers. Wi.

Ver. 12. One of them, a prophet of their own.[9] He does not mean a true prophet, but as the pretended prophets of Baal were called prophets. S. Paul understands Epimenides, a poet of Crete, who by some pagan authors was thought to know things to come; but Aristotle says, he knew only things past, not to come. The ill character he gave of the Cretians was, that they were always liars, evil beasts, slothful bellies, addicted to idleness and sensual pleasures. Wi.

Ver. 13. This testimony, or character, says the apostle, is true, by public fame of them, and therefore they must be rebuked sharply,[10] their condition and dispositions requiring it; which, therefore, is not contrary to the admonition he gave to Timothy, to be gentle towards all. 2 Tim. ii. 24. Wi.

Ver. 14. Jewish fables, and commandments of men. False traditions of the Jewish doctors, which were multiplied at that time. Calvin pretended from hence, that holydays and fasting days, and all ordinances of the Catholic Church were to be rejected as null, because they are the precepts of men. By the same argument must be rejected all laws and commands of princes and civil magistrates, as being the precepts of men. Fine doctrine! He might have remembered what S. Paul taught, (Rom. xiii.) that all power is from God; and what Christ said, (Lu. x. 16,) "He that hears you, hears me," &c. He might have observed that the men the apostle here speaks of, had turned[11] away themselves from the Christian faith. Wi.

Ver. 15. All things are clean to the clean. That is, no creature is evil of its own nature; and the distinction of animals, clean and unclean, is now out of date, as are the other ceremonies of the Jewish law. And that to these unfaithful, defiled men, nothing is clean, because their consciences are defiled when they make use of them against their conscience. Wi. — S. Paul here tells Titus, to be particularly on his guard against those who wished to introduce among Christians a distinction of meats, and to preach up the necessity of divers purifications prescribed by the Mosaic law. All kinds of meats, he says, are clean to those who preserve their hearts free from sin; it is not what enters into the body defiles a man; it is from the heart that proceed

wicked desires and wicked counsels: those defile a man. But to eat with unwashed hands; to eat swine's flesh, or meat that has been offered to idols: these things in themselves are indifferent actions, though particular circumstances may make them criminal. 1 Cor. viii. 4, 5, 6, &c. Calmet. — But to the defiled, &c. On the contrary, the man whose soul is defiled with sin, or who lives in infidelity, never can possess purity of heart; whatever legal washings or purifications, whatever sacrifices or ceremonies of the law he may make use of, all these cannot wash away the stains of the soul. Estius. Men. Tir.

Ver. 16. They confess that they know God. He speaks not therefore of those who were properly infidels, without the knowledge of the true God; so that it is foolish to pretend from hence, that every action of an infidel must be a sin. Wi.

[1] V. 2. Qui non mentitur, o apseudes.

[2] Ibid. Ante tempora sæcularia, pro chronon aionion.

[3] V. 4. Dilecto filio, Gnesio tekno.

[4] V. 5. Ut corrigas, epidiorthose, ut supercorrigas.

[5] Ibid. Per civitates presbyteros, presbuteros. S. Chrys. (p. 387) tous episkopous.

[6] V. 7. Non superbum. S. Jerom says, non tumidum, me authade. See Corn. a Lapide and Legh's Critica. 2 Pet. ii. 10.

[7] V. 8. Continentem, egkrate. The Prot. translate the verb, (1 Cor. vii. 9.) If they cannot contain, let them marry.

[8] V. 11. Universas domos, olous oikous.

[9] V. 12. Propheta, prophetes. Cretenses, semper mendaces, malæ bestiae, ventres pigri; Kretes, aei pseustai, kaka theria, gasteres argai. Aristotle, l. iii.

Rhetor. c. xvii. Epimenides ille de futuris non vaticinabatur: peri ton esomenon ouk emanteueto, alla peri ton gegonoton. — Kretixeiin was proverbially used for uttering falsehood, and it was a received adage, and very illiberal on the inhabitants of Crete, Cappadocia, and Cilicia.

Kretes, Kappadokes, Kilikes, tria Kappa Kakista.

[10] V. 13. Durè, apotomos; a metaphor from surgeons cutting.

[11] V. 14. Adversantium se a veritate, apostrephomenon.

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TITUS 2

CHAPTER II.

Ver. 1. Sound doctrine. It is not sufficient to teach sound doctrine, says S.

Jerom, if it be not at the same time taught in a manner worthy of itself; that is, if he who teaches it by his words belies it in his actions. S. Jerom.

Ver. 2. Be sober. The Greek Fathers, Theodoret, and Theophylactus, translate the word, sober, attentive, or vigilant. But Latin interpreters understand it of sobriety, in the literal meaning of the word. Old men oftentimes under pretense of weakness, drink wine to excess. The ancients called wine the milk of old men; hence aquilæ senectus has passed into a proverb, to designate an old man who drinks much and eats little. Calmet.

Ver. 3. In holy attire.[1] See 1 Tim. ii. 9. The Greek word is sometimes used to signify the whole constitution, or state of a man's health in all the parts of his body: here it is taken for a woman's whole exterior carriage, her gait, gesture, looks, discourse, dress, that nothing appear but what is edifying. Wi.

Ver. 4. Love their husbands. This is the first lesson he wishes to be given to young women; that they should always manifest a love, an attachment, respect and obedience to their husbands. But it must be a chaste love. Vult eas amare viros suos castè; vult inter virum et mulierem esse pudicam dilectionem. S.

Jerom.

Ver. 5. Discreet, chaste, sober. In the Greek is nothing for sober. The Latin interpreter seems to have added it, as another signification of one of the Greek words. See 1 Tim. iii. 2. Wi.

Ver. 7. In gravity: to which is added in the Prot. sincerity,[2] from some Greek copies; but it is left out by Dr. Wells, as being not in the best Greek MSS. nor is it in the Amsterdam edition, (1711.) Wi.

Ver. 9. Servants to be obedient. Servants owe respect and submission to their masters in every thing not contrary to the law, or the will of God. Hence they are strictly forbidden to murmur at their commands, to show any repugnance to obey them, or to censure their conduct. To avoid these evils, they ought to consider their masters as Jesus Christ himself, and their commands as those of God himself: which S. Paul often inculcates in other places in his epistles.

Ephes. vi. 5, 6. Colos. iii. 23. S. Jerom.

Ver. 10. Not defrauding.[3] S. Jerom puts, not stealing. The Greek signifies private thefts. Dr. Wells, not by filching. — That they may adorn (or give honour to) the doctrine of God, our Saviour, in all things; by whom we may understand God, i.e. Christ, God and Man, or God as common to the three divine persons. Wi. — Thus ought they to shew forth in their whole conduct that strict love of justice and sanctity which the Catholic faith inspires into those who profess it, and live up to the admirable rules it prescribes; thus alone can they be said to do honour to their religion, when they practically perform what they speculatively believe.

Ver. 11. For the grace of God, our Saviour, hath appeared to all men. In the Greek: For the saving grace of God, &c. Wi.

Ver. 12. We should live soberly,[4] and justly, and piously. S. Jerom puts (as in other places for the same Greek word) chastely, justly, and piously. The words comprehend man's duty to himself, to his neighbour, and towards God. Wi.

Ver. 13. Waiting for the blessed hope; for the happiness of the blessed in heaven, promised and hoped for. — And coming of the glory of the great God,

[5] and our Saviour Jesus Christ. The title of great God, says Dr. Wells, is here referred to our Saviour Jesus Christ, by Clem. of Alex. in protreptico, c. vi. He might have added, and by the general consent of the Greek and Latin Fathers.

S. Chrys. here cries out: "where are now they who say that the Son is less than the Father?" S. Jerom in like manner: "where is the serpent Arius? where is the snake Eunomius?" And that this title of great God is here given to Jesus Christ, may be shewn from the text itself, especially in the Greek; for the glorious coming, and appearance, in other places of S. Paul, is always used to signify Christ's coming to judge the world. Secondly, inasmuch as one and the same Greek article falls upon the great God, and our Saviour Christ; so that even M. Simon, in a note on these words, says the construction is, and the coming of Jesus Christ, the great God, our Saviour, and blames Erasmus and Grotius for pretending that this place is not a confutation of the Arians. Wi.

Ver. 14. A people, particularly acceptable.[6] S. Jerom translates an egregious or eminent people. He says in the Sept. it corresponds to segula, which signifies a man's proper possessions, which he has purchased or chosen for himself. Budeus says it signifies what is rare and uncommon; and it is well translated by the Protestants, a particular people. Wi.

[1] V. 3. In habitu sancto, en katastemati ieroprepeis. Scapula, out of Dioscorus, says katastema is constitutio naturalis corporis. See S. Jer. p. 426.

[2] V. 7. In some Greek is added aphtharsian, sincerity.

[3] V. 10. Non fraudantes, me nosphezomenous, non suffurantes.

[4] V. 12. Sobriè, justè, et piè. S. Jerom in his commentary, castè justè, et piè.

So he generally translates sophron, sophronos, &c.

[5] V. 13. Adventum gloriæ magni Dei, et Salvatoris nostri Jesu Christi; epiphaneian tes doxes tou megalou Theou kai Soteris emon Iesou Christou.

S. Chrys. (p. 401. lin. 43.) pou eisin oi tou Patros, elattona ton uion legontes. S.

Jer. "Ubi est serpens Arius? ubi est Eunomius coluber?" S. Paul uses epiphaneian for the coming of Christ to judgment. The same Greek article is put thus, tou megalou Theou, kai Soteris, and not kai tou Soteris.

[6] V. 14. Acceptabilem, periousion a perieimi. S. Jerom says, Egregium, præcipuum. See Deut. vii. 6. Exod. xix. 5. Psal. cxxxiv. 4. Israel in possessionem sibi. See also S. Chrys. log. i. p. 402. linea 4tâ.

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TITUS 3

CHAPTER III.

Ver. 1. Princes and powers. At the time S. Paul wrote this epistle to Titus, there were many Jews, particularly the disciples of Judas of Gaulan, who maintained that the Hebrews were under no obligation of obeying any other than God, or at most the rulers of their own nation.

S. Paul here admonishes them, that in conformity with the example and instruction of our divine Saviour, they ought likewise to obey every other temporal prince set over them by the Almighty, provided they commanded nothing contrary to the law of God. S. Jerom.

Estius. Menochius. — Piety teaches, and pastors should enforce three duties towards princes: submission to their authority, obedience to their laws, and a disposition of heart to meet all their just desires.

Ver. 3. We may see in this portrait of a child of Adam, drawn by the hand of a master, what we should have been without Jesus Christ, and what we perhaps have been, as often as he has abandoned us to ourselves. Whoever cannot read in this his own depravity, has never studied as he ought his own heart.

Ver. 4. The goodness and kindness. Lit. humanity of our Saviour. By humanity[1] some expound Christ's appearing in his human nature, but by the Greek is meant the love of God towards mankind. Wi.

Ver. 5. Not by the works, &c. S. Paul in this verse alludes to the sacrament of baptism. This text is brought by divines to prove that baptism, like every other sacrament, produces its effect by its own power, (or, as it is termed in the schools, ex opere operato) independently of any disposition on the part of the receiver. We are saved, says the apostle, not by the works of justice, or any good works we have performed, but our salvation must be attributed solely to the mercy of our Saviour, God, manifested to us by the washing itself of regeneration and renovation of the Holy Ghost. — By the laver of regeneration,

&c.[2] That is, baptism, by which we are born anew the adoptive children of God, by the grace of the Holy Ghost, whom he hath poured, &c. Wi.

Ver. 6. All presumption of human merits, which have not the grace of Jesus Christ for their principle, is here completely confounded; and the whole glory of our salvation is justly attributed to the mercy of God, through Jesus Christ.

A new birth, new creature, new spirit. The effusion of the water upon the body in baptism, is a figure of the salutary effusion of the holy Spirit in the soul to renew it, and to make it a child of God.

Ver. 7. This admirable, and I may say divine adoption, is the sole foundation of a Christian's hope, as the eternal life of the blessed is the sole end of this adoption.

Ver. 8. It is a faithful saying. He means what he has already said, of our being justified by the grace and mercies of God. — And of these things I will have thee to affirm[3] earnestly. The sense is not, I would herein confirm thee, (as Mr. N. translates, without attention to the Greek, which in so many places shews us the literal sense of the Latin text) but that he would have his disciple, Titus, to confirm and settle others in the belief of these truths, that, as it follows, they may be careful to excel in good works. Wi.

Ver. 10. A man that is, &c. Many ancient copies have this passage thus, Avoid a heretic after one reprehension. S. Irenæus, Tertullian, S. Cyprian, Ambrose, &c.

and many ancient Greek copies, omit a second reprehension. They thought once warning a heretic sufficient; a second correction only served to render him more insolent, and more obstinate in his false opinions. Certainly the faith of Christ has been so firmly established, that a man instructed in Scripture and tradition cannot conscientiously remain a heretic; he must be well aware of the crime of disunion; his own judgment, as S. Paul says, must condemn him.

Ver. 11. Knowing that he that is such a one is subverted:[4] a metaphor, from a house that is thrown down, even to the foundation, by the Greek. He speaks of heretics whose obstinacy seems evident, for no one is properly a heretic but who is obstinate in his errors. — And sinneth, being[5] condemned; or, condemned by his own judgment, when his ignorance cannot be a sufficient plea for him. Wi. — Other offenders are judged and cast out of the Church by the sentence of the pastors of the same Church. Heretics, more unhappy, run out of the Church of

their own accord; and by so doing, give judgment and sentence against their own souls. Ch.

Ver. 14. Let our men (that is, all Christians) also learn to excel in good and charitable works, by furnishing to others, for necessary uses, according to their wants. Wi.

Ver. 15. There is no tie so tender or so strong as that of faith and charity.

Nothing unites us truly together, but that which unites us all to God and to Jesus Christ, by an union of the same sentiments of faith, the same emotions of love, and the same inclinations of grace.

[1] V. 4. Benignitas et humanitas, chrestotes kai philanthropia. See Estius.

[2] V. 5. Lavacrum, loutron. See Ephes. v. 26.

[3] V. 8. De his volo te confirmare, peri touton boulomai se diabebaioushai: on which S. Chrys. says, (log. st. p. 406.) toutesti, tauta dialegesthai; I would have to declare these things, &c.

[4] V. 11. Subversus est, exestraptai, eversus est.

[5] Ibid. Proprio judicio condemnatus, autokatakritos.

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